

# Labour Supply 3: Labour Supply Over the Life Cycle

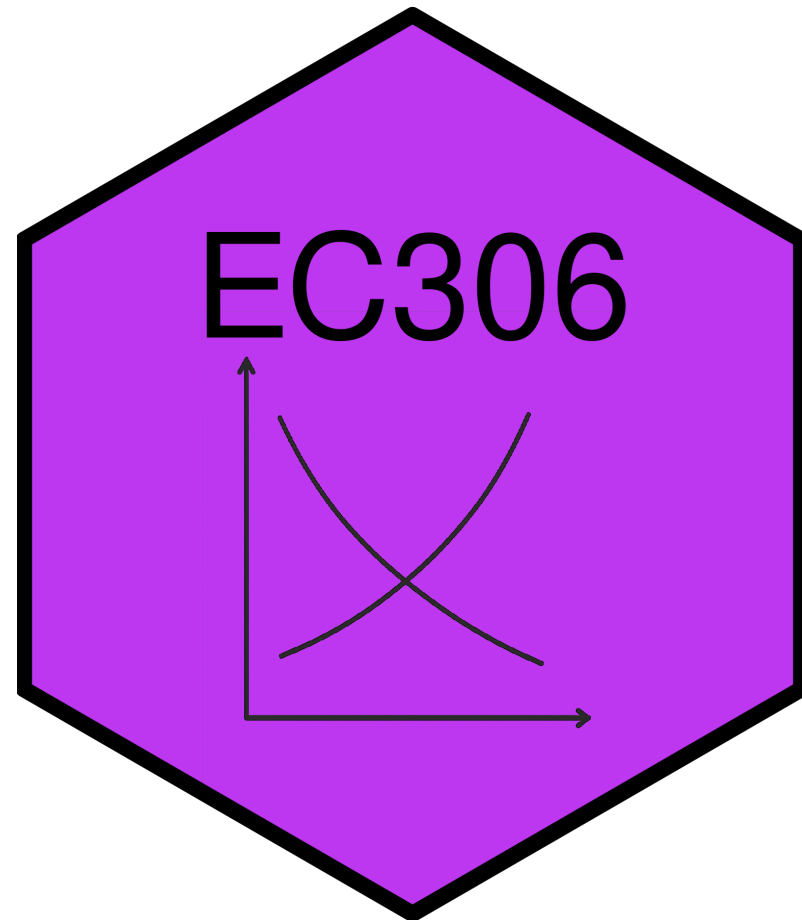
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EC306- Wages and Employment

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# Goals of This Section

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In this section we will:

- Show patterns of labour supply over a person's lifetime
- Discuss issues comparing labour supply of people at different ages
- Introduce lifetime labour supply model
- Discuss household production
- Analyze retirement decisions

# Life Cycle Labour Supply

# Introduction

## Previous discussion:

- Focused on labour supply at a moment in time
- Supply changed immediately in response to wages, non-labour income, or policies

## In reality:

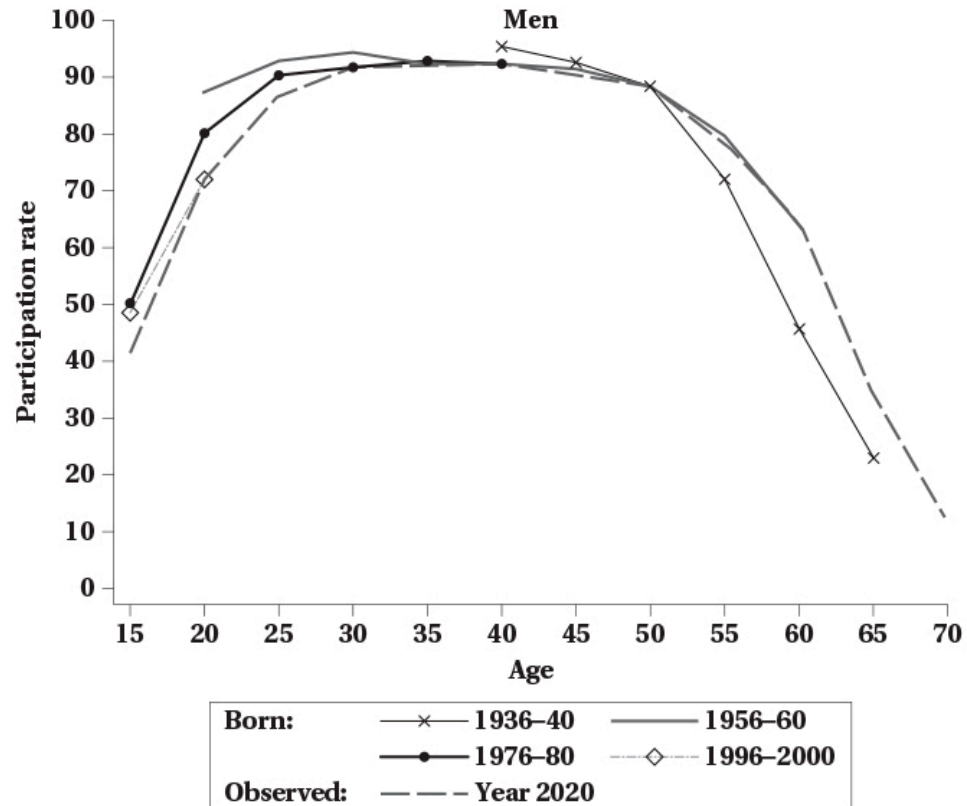
- People can plan work over their lifetime
- Participation is highest in prime working years
- Life events alter labour supply decisions now and in the future
  - Marriage, children, education, health, retirement



Tip

A life cycle approach helps us understand these patterns

# Life Cycle Participation for Men



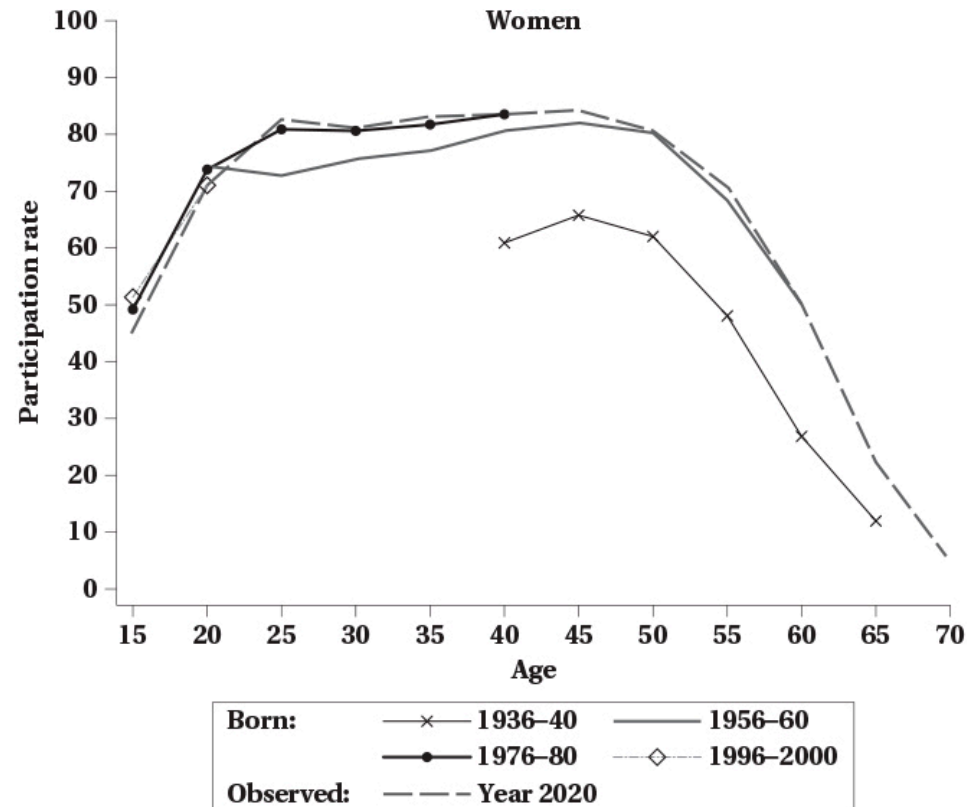
Graph follows labour supply of men born in different years

- Participation rises quickly in early 20s, peaks in late 40s, then declines

Differences across birth cohorts:

- At younger ages, younger cohorts participate a bit less
- At older ages, younger cohorts participate more

# Life Cycle Participation for Women



Women follow similar lifetime pattern

- Rates are shifted down a bit relative to men
- Participation **higher for younger cohorts** at all ages
  - Consistent with rising female labour force participation over time

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## ! The Problem with Cross-Sectional Data

When we look at participation by age in a single year, we are mixing **age effects** and **cohort effects**

Previous graphs highlight a technical point:

- Each graph contains a line that looks at life cycle pattern in year 2020
  - Participation of people in 2020 at different ages
- Problem: people at different ages are born at different times
  - 20 year olds in 2020 born in 2000
  - 60 year olds in 2020 born in 1960

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## Definitions:

- **Age effects:** how labour supply changes as people get older
- **Cohort effects:** how labour supply differs for people born at different times

## Cohort effects can be significant

- In particular for women where it has been increasing for younger cohorts
- Cannot look at participation by age in a single year and interpret as pure age effects

## Better approach:

- Look at participation by age for a single birth cohort
- This is done in the graphs on the previous two slides
- Notice that the lines shift up and down for different birth cohorts
- Pattern across age is similar but there are some differences

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## Practical Challenge

Very few datasets have data on the same people over their entire life

### Difficulties:

- Hard to track people over time
- People die, move, refuse to respond
- Data that does track people are often restricted access

### Solution: Quasi-cohorts

- Group people by birth year in cross-sectional (single year) data
- Look at how participation changes for these groups over time
- This is what the graphs on the previous two slides do
- Can be done with the Canada Census

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

You can do this with the Canada Census:

- Census is collected every 5 years
- Each Census collects information on age and labour force status (among many other things)
- Can follow a birth cohort across different Census years as they get older

|              | Census Year |      |      |      |      |
|--------------|-------------|------|------|------|------|
| Birth Cohort | 1981        | 1986 | 1991 | 1996 | 2001 |
| 1950         | 31          | 36   | 41   | 46   | 51   |
| 1951         | 30          | 35   | 40   | 45   | 50   |
| 1952         | 29          | 34   | 39   | 44   | 49   |
| 1953         | 28          | 33   | 38   | 43   | 48   |
| 1954         | 27          | 32   | 37   | 42   | 47   |
| 1955         | 26          | 31   | 36   | 41   | 46   |

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## Caveat

In each Census year, people in a birth cohort are different people — not following the exact same individuals over time. This is generally accepted as a reasonable approximation.

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## Born in 1975

| Observed in        | 2000 | 2005 | 2010 |
|--------------------|------|------|------|
| Age                | 25   | 30   | 35   |
| Participation Rate | 75%  | 80%  | 85%  |

## Born in 1980

| Observed in        | 2000 | 2005 | 2010 |
|--------------------|------|------|------|
| Age                | 20   | 25   | 30   |
| Participation Rate | 75%  | 80%  | 85%  |

Illustrates problem with following ages in single Census year

- Tracks birth cohorts across Census years
- Shows age and participation rate
- For each cohort participation rises 5 points per year
- But looking at ages in a single Census year, they appear not to change

# Cohort Effects vs Age Effects

## Where do cohort effects come from?

People are in part defined by their generation:

- Social attitudes, economic conditions and policies change over time
- Generations experience different significant events (e.g. wars, disease)

## We therefore expect cohorts to differ:

- Women born in early 1930s had higher labour supply than previous generations
- They were influenced by their mothers working during war
- Male children also more likely to be married to working women later in life

### Important

Important to separate these from effects of pure aging

## Think About It

Suppose you observe that 50-year-olds have higher labour force participation than 25-year-olds in 2025. Can you conclude that people work more as they age? Why or why not?

# Dynamic Life Cycle Models

# Introduction

We now know that labour supply varies over the life cycle

- The allocation of work over time can be modeled
- Models examine the effects on labour supply of wage changes

Wages can change in different ways:

- At different ages
- For a short time or permanently
- Anticipated or unanticipated

## Note

Different types of changes have different effects on labour supply

# Model

Individuals maximize utility over consumption and leisure over their lifetime

$$u = U(C_1, C_2, \dots, C_N, L_1, L_2, \dots, L_N)$$

- Here  $U(.)$  is a function (e.g. logarithmic, Cobb-Douglas, etc.)

To define the budget constraint:

- We can consume and work in each period
- In theory, we can consume more than our income in a period by borrowing
- We can also save some income to consume later
- Need to be conscious of the interest rate on saving and borrowing

# Model

Consider a two period model

The budget constraint says that the present value of consumption equals the present value of income:

$$C_1 + \frac{C_2}{1+r} = W_1H_1 + \frac{W_2H_2}{1+r}$$

- $r$  is the interest rate for borrowing and saving
- This is the present (period 1) value formulation

Future (period 2) value formulation:

$$(1+r)C_1 + C_2 = (1+r)W_1H_1 + W_2H_2$$

# Model

The ability to borrow and save means a person can consume more than their income in a period

Rearranging the future value of the budget:

$$C_2 = (1 + r)(W_1H_1 - C_1) + W_2H_2$$

Two cases:

- If  $W_1H_1 > C_1$ : person **saved** some income in period 1
  - Savings grows with interest:  $(1 + r)(W_1H_1 - C_1)$  to spend in period 2
- If  $W_1H_1 < C_1$ : person **borrowed** to consume more than income
  - $(1 + r)(W_1H_1 - C_1)$  is negative and reduces income in period 2

# Model

Reexpress in terms of leisure (note that  $H_t = T - L_t$ ):

$$C_1 + \frac{C_2}{1+r} + W_1 L_1 + \frac{W_2 L_2}{1+r} = W_1 T + \frac{W_2 T}{1+r}$$

Interpretation:

- You can consume two goods (consumption and leisure)
- Price of consumption is 1 in both periods
- Price of leisure is  $W_1$  in period 1 and  $W_2$  in period 2
- You consume these out of “full income”
  - Full income = income if you worked all available hours in both periods
- Period 2 values are discounted by the interest rate

# Model

If you maximize utility subject to the budget constraints:

- You get a labour supply function
- Tells you optimal labour supply as a function of wages, interest rates, lifetime resources

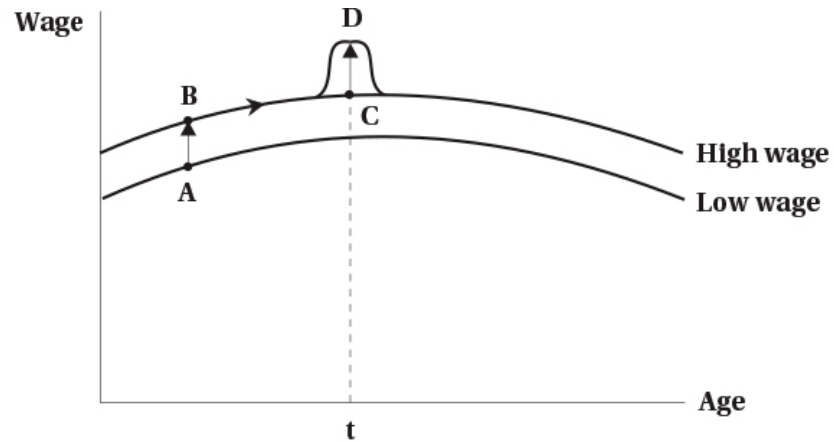
Like previous models, we can examine effects of wage changes

Three types:

1. Permanent unanticipated change in the wage in all periods
2. Anticipated future change in the wage
3. Temporary unanticipated change in the wage in one period only

These lead to substitution and income effects (more complicated because of the extra time dimension)

# Permanent Wage Change



Permanent, unanticipated change in the wage:

- Increases wage in all periods
- Shifts wage schedule up

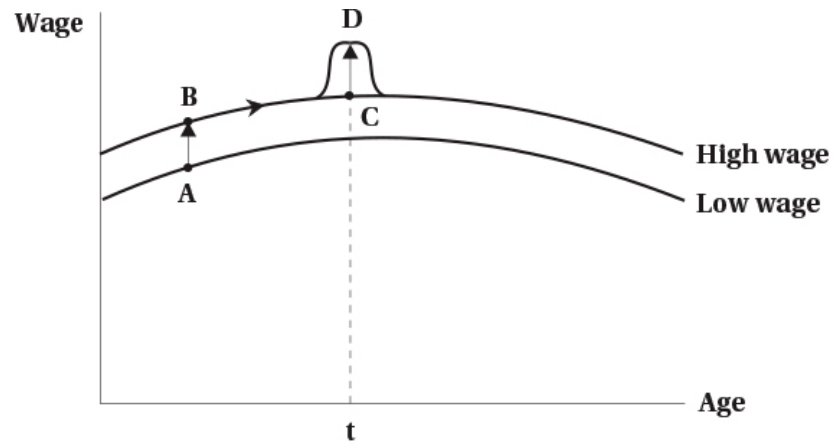
Two effects:

- **Income effect:** higher wage → higher lifetime income → more leisure (less work)
- **Substitution effect:** higher wage → leisure more expensive → less leisure (more work)

## Warning

Labour supply effect is **ambiguous**

# Anticipated Wage Change



An anticipated wage change moves person along their wage schedule

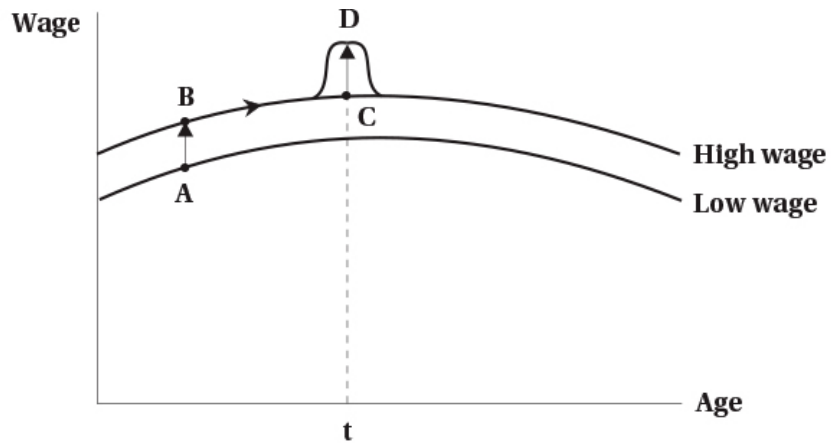
No income effect:

- Person optimized over their lifetime income
- Lifetime income has not changed

Substitution effect:

- Shifts leisure to where wage is lower
- If wage is higher in period 2, leisure is more expensive in period 2
- Less leisure in period 2 and more in period 1
- Person works more in period 2 and less in period 1

# Temporary Unanticipated Wage Change



A temporary unanticipated wage change:

- Alters wage for one period (or small number) only
- e.g. bonus pay, overtime pay
- Creates a temporary blip upward in wage schedule

Two effects:

- **Small income effect:** slightly higher lifetime income → more leisure (less work)
- **Substitution effect:** leisure more expensive in period with higher wage → less leisure (more work)

# Comparing Effects of Wage Changes

## Strongest Effect: Anticipated Wage Change

- Pure substitution effect
- No offsetting income effect

## Next Strongest: Temporary Unanticipated Change

- Substitution effect
- Small income effect
- Person works more in period with higher wage

## Ambiguous: Permanent Unanticipated Change

- Substitution effect
- Larger income effect
- Ambiguous effect on labour supply

# Evidence on Life Cycle Labour Supply

Interesting experiment on bike messengers in Zurich:

- Messengers paid a percentage of daily revenues
- Can choose their own total work hours

Research design:

- Researchers randomly assigned messengers to:
  - **Group A:** 25% higher wage for one month in September
  - **Group B:** 25% higher wage for one month in November
- Each acted as control group for the other
- Both get same increase in lifetime income, so difference is substitution effect

## Finding

 Messengers shift labour supply to periods with higher wage

## Discussion

A government announces today that the minimum wage will increase by 20% starting in two years. Using the life cycle model, how would you expect workers near the minimum wage to adjust their labour supply now versus after the increase takes effect?

# Household Production

# Introduction

## Previous Assumption

People choose between consumption and leisure, where leisure = time not working for pay

In reality, people also spend time on household production:

- Cooking, cleaning, childcare, home maintenance, shopping, etc.
- Produces goods and services that can be consumed
  - Meals, clean clothes, child supervision, etc.

In this section we explicitly model household production

# Model

People gain utility from the consumption of goods and services:

$$u = f(Z_1, Z_2, \dots, Z_N)$$

- $Z_1, Z_2, \dots, Z_n$  are final goods and services
- $f(\cdot)$  is a function (e.g. Cobb-Douglas, logarithmic, etc.)

Each good/service is produced by the household using:

- A set of market inputs  $X_1, X_2, \dots, X_n$
- Time  $h_i$

Time is divided between:

- Market work
- Household production tasks

# Model

What does it mean that households “produce” the goods they consume?

Does not mean that literally everyone is producing goods from raw materials

Instead:

Every good/service consumed requires some time to prepare

- Hiring contractors to remodel a home requires a small amount of home production
  - Time spent explaining what you need, keeping contractor on schedule
- Remodelling your basement by yourself requires much more time

In this model:

We explicitly account for substituting time between various uses:

- Work, home production of various goods, leisure

# Model

## Example: Household Consumes Two Goods

Nutrition and rest — These would be  $Z_1$  and  $Z_2$  in the utility function

Nutrition is produced using:

- Processed or raw food, and time
- These are  $X_1, X_2$  and  $h$
- Raw food takes time to prepare equal to  $h = d$  hours

Each of the three purchased goods has a price:

Processed food:

- Price per unit of nutrition is  $P_c$
- Takes no time to prepare

# Model

## Raw food:

- Price per unit of nutrition is  $P_r + W_d$
- The added time cost is valued at the wage rate  $W$  times  $d$  hours

## Leisure:

- Price is the wage rate  $W$

# Comparative Statics

What happens when we start changing some of the prices?

Increase in wage rate  $W$ :

- Cost of time affects both rest and production of raw food
- Higher wage makes home production more expensive
  - Time spent cooking becomes more expensive
  - Substitute away from home production to processed food
  - **Substitution effect**: less home production, more processed food
  - **Income effect**: higher wage  $\rightarrow$  higher income  $\rightarrow$  more consumption of all goods

# Comparative Statics

Increase in wage rate  $W$  (continued):

- Effect on rest is same as before
  - **Substitution effect:** less rest, more work
  - **Income effect:** higher income  $\rightarrow$  more rest

# Comparative Statics

Decrease in price of processed food  $P_c$ :

- Processed food becomes cheaper relative to other goods
- **Substitution effect**: more processed food, less home production
- **Income effect**: lower price  $\rightarrow$  higher real income  $\rightarrow$  more consumption of all goods

Decrease in price of raw food  $P_r$ :

- Raw food becomes relatively cheaper
- **Substitution effect**: more raw food, less processed food
- **Income effect**: lower price  $\rightarrow$  higher real income  $\rightarrow$  more consumption of all goods

# Comparative Statics

Decrease in time required to prepare raw food  $d$ :

- Example: technology that reduces cooking time (e.g. Instant Pot)
- Home production becomes relatively cheaper (through lower time cost)

Effects:

- **Substitution effect:** more raw food, less processed food
- **Additional substitution effect:** higher real wage (keep more of their wage) → less rest, more work
- **Income effect:** lower time cost → higher real income → more consumption of all goods

# Discussion

Model adds more real world complexity:

- Matches what people actually do
- Emphasizes that people do not just choose between work and leisure
- Also emphasizes the role of the household relative to the individual
  - Household members can specialize in different tasks
  - Changes for one household member can affect others

## Household Production Function

Different households have different abilities to produce goods. This can affect their choices and responses to changes in prices.

## Think About It

What would happen to a household's use of home-cooked meals versus takeout food if one partner receives a large raise at work? Explain using the household production model.

# Fertility and Childbearing

# Introduction

Fertility is a key life event that affects labour supply

- Particularly for women, but also men to some degree
- Children are typically planned to some degree
  - Timing of children is often chosen to fit with work plans
  - Number of children is often chosen based on lifetime work plans

Economists have developed models to analyze fertility decisions

- These models are similar to the life cycle labour supply model
- We will not go over the model (beyond the scope of this course)
- But we will discuss some of the key variables that affect fertility decisions

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Income

## Theoretical Prediction

Income is positively related to the number of children — higher income → higher ability to pay for children.  
Children are a “normal good.”

Some disagreement on whether children are considered a normal good:

- Empirically, higher income families and countries have **lower fertility rates**
- Explanation: substitution effect of higher income dominates income effect
  - Higher income → higher opportunity cost of time spent on children

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Price of Children

Like goods, the demand curve for children slopes down

- Higher “price” of children → fewer children are chosen

Price of children includes:

- **Direct costs:** food, clothing, housework, etc.
- **Opportunity costs:** time spent caring for children could be spent working for pay

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Price of Children

A higher price (wage rate) creates income and substitution effects:

- **Income effect:** higher wage → higher lifetime income → more children
- **Substitution effect:** higher price → time with children more expensive → fewer children

## Note

Effect is theoretically ambiguous, but empirically substitution effect dominates

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Price of Related Goods

Many goods are consumed as part of having children:

- Childcare, education, etc.
- These are **complementary goods**
  - If you have more children, you will consume more of these goods
  - You could also consider these direct costs of children

## ! Economic Principle

An increase in the price of a complementary good reduces demand. Higher price of childcare or education → fewer children.

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Tastes

Tastes for children vary across people and over time:

- Some people really want children, others do not
- Some cultures value children more than others
- Attitudes towards children have changed over time

A stronger taste for children means more children

- This is like a shift in the demand curve for children

Over time in Canada:

- There has been a shift away from children
- Fertility rates have declined over time
- People are having fewer children than in the past

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Technology

Technology in this case could mean several things:

- Could refer to the “production” of children
- Might also relate to the goods and services used with children (e.g. home automation, disposable diapers)

Key developments in the last few decades:

- **Birth control:** allows people to better plan timing and number of children
- **Fertility treatments:** allows some people to have children who otherwise could not
- **Medical care:** reduces infant mortality, so fewer children needed to ensure some survive
- **Home technology:** reduces time cost of childcare, so lower opportunity cost of children

# Variables Affecting Fertility - Technology



Tip

Higher technology in any of these areas tends to increase demand for children

# Empirical Evidence

Economists have examined the relationship between income and fertility

## Challenge: Omitted Variables

A simple correlation between income and fertility tends to be negative. Important to hold constant other variables that affect both income and fertility.

## Example:

- Education levels are positively related to income and negatively related to fertility

## When other variables are held constant:

- Income tends to be positively related to fertility
- Consistent with children being a normal good
- Tax incentives also tend to increase fertility

## Discussion

Why might we observe that countries with the most generous parental leave policies do not necessarily have the highest fertility rates?

# Retirement and Pensions

# Introduction

Retirement is a key life event that affects labour supply

- Most people retire at some point
- Retirement age has been changing over time

It can mean many things:

- Permanent exit from the labour force
- A reduction to part-time work
- Retiring from one full-time job and taking another

For most people:

Retirement means permanent exit from the labour force

# Determinants of Retirement - Age

## ! Most Important Determinant

Age is the most important determinant of retirement

- Most people retire between ages 60 and 70
- Very few people retire before age 50 or after age 75

## Mandatory retirement:

- In Canada it is generally illegal to force retirement based on age
- Except if deemed a bona fide occupational requirement (BFOR)
  - Like for pilots, police, firefighters, air traffic controllers
- Still exists in other parts of the world (e.g. Japan, China, parts of Europe)

# Determinants of Retirement - Wealth/Earnings

Wealth in our model entered as non-labour earnings:

- Higher wealth → higher non-labour income
- Higher non-labour income → more leisure (less work)

Earnings changes have income and substitution effects:

- **Income effect:** higher earnings → higher lifetime income → more leisure (less work)
- **Substitution effect:** higher earnings → leisure more expensive → less leisure (more work)

Can also think of this in a lifecycle model

# Determinants of Retirement - Other

Health is an important determinant:

- Poor health can force people to retire early
- Good health can allow people to work longer
- Health of family members can also play a role
- Might operate through non-labour income or preferences

# Determinants of Retirement - Other

## Changing nature of work:

- Move towards less physically demanding jobs can prolong work life
- More flexible work arrangements can allow people to work longer
- Alternatively, more stressful jobs can lead to earlier retirement
- Automation might force early retirement
- Could affect the budget constraint or preferences

# Determinants of Retirement - Other

## Changing nature of family:

- Many more two-earner families now
  - Can lead to earlier retirement for one spouse
  - Or could prolong work if spouses want to work together longer
- Children living at home for longer can affect retirement timing
- Increase in caring for elderly parents can lead to earlier or later retirement
- Might affect budget constraint or preferences

# Retirement Income

## ! Major Effect on Retirement Decisions

Public and private pension plans determine most income in retirement

The pension system in Canada consists of:

### 1. Old Age Security (OAS)

- A flat rate pension available to most Canadians over age 65
- Funded out of general tax revenues
- Monthly max is \$740 for those aged 65-74, \$814 for those 75+
- Clawback for high income earners (above \$148,000 in 2024)
- Supplemented by the Guaranteed Income Supplement (GIS) for low income seniors

# Retirement Income

## 2. Canada/Quebec Pension Plan (CPP/QPP)

- Earnings-related pension available to those who have contributed
- Funded by contributions from employees, employers, and self-employed
- Monthly max is \$1,433 in 2025 (age 65)
- Can start receiving as early as age 60 (reduced) or as late as age 70 (increased)
- Based on average earnings over working life, up to a maximum limit

# Retirement Income

## 3. Employer Pension Plans

- Many employers offer pension plans to employees
- Can be defined benefit or defined contribution plans
- Vary widely in terms of benefits and eligibility
- Includes private savings from RRSPs

# Old Age Security

What effect does OAS have on retirement decisions?

Operates as a lump sum transfer:

- Increases non-labour income
- Creates income effect: more leisure (less work)
- No substitution effect because it does not change the wage rate

GIS operates like a negative income tax:

- People get the lump sum payment
- Payments reduced by \$0.50 for each dollar of work income
- Has work incentives equal to a negative income tax

# Canada/Quebec Pension Plan

The effect of pension income on retirement depends on how it is structured

In Canada currently, it is simply a fixed payment:

- Increases non-labour income
- Creates income effect: more leisure (less work)
- No substitution effect because it does not change the wage rate

In the past, there was a provision that reduced benefits if you worked:

- Similar to a negative income tax
- If the tax back rate is 100%, then it is like pure welfare
- Could also not tax back until a certain income level

# Employer Pension Plan

Generally involve a fixed payment based on years of service and earnings

- Increases non-labour income
- Creates income effect: more leisure (less work)
- No substitution effect because it does not change the wage rate

Over time the parameters that determine the fixed payment can change:

- This can alter work incentives at retirement
- Example: if the benefit formula is changed to require more years of service
  - Would reduce the income effect of the pension
  - Could also create a substitution effect to work more to get the pension

# Evidence on Effect of Pensions

## Main Finding

Studies find that pensions affect retirement in expected ways

- Pensions that increase non-labour income lead to **earlier retirement**
- Pensions that create work incentives lead to **later retirement**

## More recent work:

- Increase in retirement age increases working-age disability claims in UK
- Increasing public pension participation improves health behaviours (less smoking)
- Pension reform allowing Japanese spouses to claim half of pension earnings increased divorce

## Think About It

If the government reduced CPP benefits but simultaneously eliminated the clawback on OAS for high earners, what would be the combined effect on the retirement age of high-income workers?

# Summary

# Summary

## Labour supply varies over the life cycle

- Participation highest in prime working years
- A life cycle approach helps us understand these patterns

## Dynamic life cycle models can analyze effects of wage changes:

- Permanent unanticipated changes
- Anticipated future changes
- Temporary unanticipated changes

## Household production is an important part of labour supply decisions

- People allocate time between work, household production, and leisure
- Changes in prices of goods and time costs affect these choices

# Summary

Fertility decisions are affected by:

Income, prices, tastes, and technology

Retirement decisions are affected by:

Age, wealth, health, family, and pensions